DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

Can One Hasid Atone for the Whole World?

Derech Hashem 2:3:8-9

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 2, Chapter 3, paragraphs 8 (second half) and 9 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 3 June 2021

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Review: the saddik who atones for his generation

The class picks up halfway through paragraph 8, at the words "veulam, mizeh hasug asmo." Last time the Ramhal explained that a saddik may suffer through no fault of his own, not for cleansing and not to awaken him, but as an atonement for his generation (kapparat hador). If he accepts it with love, saying "even though I don't deserve it, I understand that Hashem does it for the good," he elevates everyone connected to him and is himself raised to the very top: in the image of the stadium, "the executive box."

A participant asked whether this is what is called yissurim shel ahavah. The Rabbi said it is close, but usually that term refers to suffering that cleanses a person of his own sins so that he can reach the World to Come.

Iyov, and why we do not explain other people's suffering

Another participant asked whether Iyov fits this category. The Rabbi said that what exactly Iyov was is complex. He noted the opinion in the Gemara in Bava Batra that Iyov never existed and the book is a mashal, and the Ramban's introduction to the book, which he called fascinating. The Ramban explains that the book teaches the many possible reasons why the righteous suffer, and the final lesson is that we cannot know the exact reason in any given case. Iyov's friends kept offering explanations, and none was good enough.

From this the Rabbi drew a practical rule: do not practise theodicy on people while they are suffering. When he teaches this subject in public he always says that he is not answering personal questions. "I can tell you a framework with how you can think about your own life. But anyone who tells you that this is because of that, they're talking nonsense. No one knows." Only a prophet could say.

The same applies to the common claim that when a saddik dies it was to stop a decree coming on Israel. It is possible, and the Torah itself links Miriam's death to atonement. But we cannot know it for certain about a particular person. "We can hope that. We can pray that."

A higher category: the Hasid

The Ramhal now says that within this category there is a level higher still. These are the greatest hasidim, who are completely perfect in themselves. They do not only atone for the people around them. They take part in the whole chain of events that leads to the final perfection of the world.

The background is that since the sin of Adam, the world and its creatures are in a damaged state, the result of Hashem's concealment of His face, which deepens with every sin. Besides the judgement of each individual, there is a general plan: the world must reach its goal, and a certain amount of suffering has to happen for the attribute of justice to be satisfied. Hashem decided that the more perfect individuals can carry that and repair it on behalf of others.

The Rabbi asked the group what the difference is between the saddik and the hasid, and summed it up: - **The saddik** atones for his generation: his friends, his community, his city, perhaps his country, anyone connected to him. - **The hasid** atones for the whole chain of history, back to the sin of Adam and on to the end. Not only for people, but for the damage in creation itself.

He connected this to the master plan the Ramhal will explain in Part 4: Hashem leads the world both by justice, judging each of us, and by a higher guidance that ensures the world reaches its final target whether or not we are worthy. That is why Mashiah will come if we are worthy, and if not, he will come anyway.

The source is the Gemara in Sukkah (fourth chapter), where Rabbi Shimon bar Yohai says he can exempt the world from judgement from his own day; with his son, from the beginning; and with a third, until the end. He also mentioned that in Rabbi Shimon's lifetime no rainbow was seen, an expression of the same idea.

"Do they just get away with it?"

A participant asked whether this means those atoned for get away with their sins. Another participant answered that it depends where they end up in the stadium, and the Rabbi called it an excellent point. No one can do your work for you. He gave a halachic example: a non-Jewish man who wants to convert needs both milah and mikveh. If a medical condition prevents milah, "no one's blaming you," but he still cannot convert. Being exempt is not the same as having done it.

So too here. You may be spared the punishment, but you will be on a lower level. "If you haven't developed yourself intellectually, your character traits... no one can do that for you."

He repeated his warning from last week that this idea sounds very Christian and has been misused: people who rely on attaching themselves to a Rebbe or travelling to Uman, without learning or growing themselves. A connection to the righteous is "a nice thing to have," but "you don't build your future on that." Still, the result is that very few people will be left outside altogether. "Sometimes it pays to be connected to the right people."

Quality outweighs quantity

Because the saddik and the hasid are perfect in themselves and suffer voluntarily for others, a small amount of their suffering satisfies the attribute of justice in place of a great deal that

would otherwise fall on ordinary people. One saddik can atone for a hundred thousand. Quality outdoes quantity. And by accepting it with love they grow greater still, and can repair even more. The hasidim of the second category will be "the head of the head," the closest of all to Hashem: "literally the dugout. You can't get any nearer."

Paragraph 9: this is reality, not a vending machine

Paragraph 9 opens: "Vehineh, kol mah shezakharnu..." Everything said so far is not only justice in the sense of reward and consequence. It is reality. The Rabbi stressed that the Ramhal repeats this often: "Don't treat religion, don't treat HaKadosh Barukh Hu, as a vending machine, that you press this and this happens."

Sin creates pollution. The more pollution, the more Hashem's light is hidden, concealment upon concealment. When people are cleansed of it, His light returns and is revealed. Suffering has the power to atone and to cleanse that pollution, both for individuals and for humanity as a whole, and through it the world itself comes closer to perfection.

Coming next: gilgul

The Rabbi listed the reasons so far: cleansing, your role, awakening to teshuvah, continuing from your parents, and atonement for the generation. The last one, to be learned on Monday, is gilgul: a righteous person may suffer simply because he has something to repair from a previous life. Since you are your soul and not your body, a soul that left this world still needing cleansing can return in a new body. He posed the question to think about: is there any source in Tanakh or Gemara for gilgul? The answer, he promised, is surprising.

Summary

- Above the saddik who atones for his generation stands the hasid, who carries the repair of all history and of creation itself (Sukkah, Rabbi Shimon bar Yohai).
- We may learn the principles of why people suffer, but no one can say why a particular person suffers; that was Iyov's friends' mistake.
- Atonement through another does not do your work for you: you are spared punishment but remain on a lower level.
- One perfect person's suffering can outweigh that of multitudes, and accepting it with love raises him higher still.
- Paragraph 9: these are not arbitrary rewards but reality; sin conceals Hashem's light and cleansing reveals it.

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